

Evolutionary Study of Horror Literature

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Evolutionary literary theory has in recent years grown from a small movement at the periphery of the literary establishment to a much more visible and productive school (Carroll 2018). While most evolutionary literary theorists focus on canonical literature,¹ some scholars have begun to approach popular literary genres such as horror from an evolutionary perspective (Vanderbeke and Cooke in press). An evolutionary approach to literature entails a commitment to evolutionary psychology, which posits that the human mind evolved in an adaptive relationship to its environment over millions of years. In contrast to blank-slate psychologies, which claim that human minds have no innate structure, evolutionary psychologists suggest human minds are richly structured “in advance of experience” (Pinker 2002, Haidt 2012, p. 131). Humans universally have motives and dispositions that evolved in response to adaptive challenges. Such motives and dispositions give rise to culture. Thus, to understand culture, including literature and its oral antecedents, one must understand the minds that produce culture (Carroll 2013). Evolutionary literary theorists are interested in the evolved psychological mechanisms that underpin imagination and storytelling practices, and in the adaptive functions of such practices. Evolutionary horror scholars, specifically, claim that we can understand horror fiction as a cultural technology that works by tapping into ancient, defensive psychological mechanisms to satisfy an adaptive appetite for vicarious experience with scenarios of danger. Moreover, they claim that evolutionary interpretative practice gains epistemological strength from being integrated with the evolutionary social sciences (Clasen 2017b). Evolutionary horror study is still an emerging enterprise, however, and much theoretical and interpretative work remains to be done.

Evolutionary Horror Study: A Brief Historical Overview

The first scholar to do a sustained analysis of horror fiction from a theoretical position informed by evolutionary thinking was H. P. Lovecraft. In his long essay, *Supernatural Horror in Literature* (written 1925-1927 and revised 1933-1934), Lovecraft famously claimed that the “oldest and strongest emotion of mankind is fear, and the oldest and strongest kind of fear is fear of the unknown ... As may naturally be expected of a form so closely connected with primal emotion, the horror-tale is as old as human thought and speech themselves” (2000, p. 23) Lovecraft thus suggested a causal link between human nature and horror stories. Many of Lovecraft’s key claims about the evolved underpinnings of horror have since been vindicated by scientific research (Clasen under submission). However, rather than giving rise to a dynamic research paradigm on horror and human nature, Lovecraft’s essay languished for much of the twentieth century and had little impact on subsequent horror study. When academic horror study became institutionally established during the 1980s, most academics with an interest in horror operated within constructivist paradigms that disregarded biological reality or adopted psychoanalytical ideas disconnected from psychological reality (Clasen 2017b). Even as evolutionary theory was transforming social science and as the empirical evidence against blank-slate thinking and orthodox psychoanalysis accumulated, few humanist scholars—let alone horror scholars—heeded these developments. A few isolated, evolutionarily-informed publications on horror literature and film emerged in the new millennium, including work by Torben Grodal, Benson Saler and Charles A. Ziegler, David Swanger, Robert King, Stephen A. Asma, and the present author.² The evolutionary approach to horror literature is not very widespread yet, but scholars are making advances in charting the evolved underpinnings and adaptive functions of horror literature and in developing an evolutionary interpretative paradigm for horror study.

Horror and Negative Emotion

Evolutionary horror scholars focus, as a first step, on the emotions targeted by horror, and they explain that those emotions are a result of biological evolution. As many scholars have observed, horror is affectively defined, that is, by its intended reader reaction.³ That intended reader reaction encompasses negative emotional responses. Horror is meant to frighten and disturb its audience; it promises to elicit negative emotions—fear, terror, dread, anxiety, disgust—in its readership. Thus, horror is often marketed on its ability to disturb readers. When Stephen King said of Paul Tremblay’s 2015 possession novel *Head Full of Ghosts* that it “scared the living hell” out of him (“and I’m pretty hard to scare”), Tremblay’s publishers printed that paradoxical approbation on the cover of the next edition, and sales soared. Horror literature typically achieves its affective aim by depicting relatable characters clashing with antagonistic forces. Through perspective-taking and, more often than not, sympathetic identification with these characters, the reader mirrors their horror at being preyed on by supercharged predators—from werewolves to wendigos—or immaterial, morally polarized forces such as the evil ghosts that populate the Overlook Hotel in King’s *The Shining* (Clasen 2017a). We respond emotionally to such depictions because they tap into our evolved fear system.

The negative emotions prototypically evoked by and depicted in horror stories are phenomenologically distinct but functionally united. They feel slightly different, but all evolved to protect the organism from harm. Disgust protects us from pathogens; fear protects us from assault; anxiety, terror, and dread ready us for confrontation with remote or abstract threats. Negative emotions have their wellspring in an ancient mammalian fear system, and once activated they are difficult to consciously extinguish (Öhman and Mineka 2001). The fear system is adaptively biased to err on the side of caution. Humans, like other mammals, evolved to react strongly to even ambiguous cues of danger—a rustling in the leaves, say, or a noise in the dead of night. This bias is adaptive because a false negative is much more costly than a false positive. If we react with fear to a strange noise that turns out to be floorboards settling, we will have lost little. If, conversely, we fail to react to a strange noise that turns out to signal impending

assault, we may lose everything (Marks and Nesse 1994). This design characteristic helps explain why humans scare easily—so easily, in fact, that even holding in one’s imagination a particularly vivid representation of danger produces a range of downstream physiological effects such as elevated heart rate, goosebumps, and perspiration.

Horror literature can exploit the whole range of negative emotion. Fear and anxiety are probably the most commonly targeted emotions in horror, but many stories also aim to elicit visceral disgust through the depiction of body-envelope violations or moral disgust through the depiction of sadistic, anti-social violence toward protagonists. Jack Ketchum’s *The Girl Next Door*, for example, powerfully elicits moral disgust through the depiction of a deranged suburban family’s murderous abuse of an innocent girl. Some writers depict conceptually disturbing material and aim at eliciting terror, such as the response ideally produced by a Lovecraft or a Thomas Ligotti story—a terror elicited not so much through the depiction of sympathetic characters in peril or the depiction of fearsome monsters, but through a suggestion of a fundamentally hostile or meaningless cosmos. Dread, while related to terror and anxiety, is elicited by stories that suggest the ominous presence of some vaguely defined or dimly understood yet massive evil (Freeland 2004). Shirley Jackson’s *The Haunting of Hill House*, through its elusive suggestion of a malicious supernatural force working insidiously on a highly unstable narrator, aims to elicit dread. All these various emotional responses have their roots in the evolved fear system. Thus, an understanding of the structure of this system, and of the evolutionary forces that shaped it, helps scholars make sense of how and why horror literature can so powerfully move us. Horror stories invite us to participate imaginatively in virtual worlds that teem with danger. That danger often takes the form of monsters.

Horror and Monsters

Horror stories tend to be structured around monsters, and most such monsters reflect ancestral dangers (Carrol, Noël 1990). By monsters, I mean dangerous, evil, more or less unnatural agents. Pennywise the Dancing Clown from Stephen King's *It* is evil, dangerous, and unnatural in its ability to violate the laws of physics (Clasen 2014). The suburban monsters in Ketchum's *The Girl Next Door* are not unnatural, but they are dangerous and evil in their psychotic disregard for others' suffering and in the sadistic pleasure they take in degradation and torture. Horror monsters have qualities that allow them to exploit the human fear system. We evolved to be particularly attentive to certain kinds of danger, including the danger posed by predators and hostile conspecifics (Coss and Goldthwaite 1995, Barrett 2005). Many horror monsters are exaggerations of ancestral predators, that is, supercharged variations of the kinds of alpha predators that have preyed on humans and our hominin ancestors for millions of years (Clasen 2010, Asma 2015). That is why a dramatic depiction of a vengeful shark is much more imaginatively and emotionally compelling than a dramatic depiction of a vengeful cow, even though more people are killed globally by cows than sharks. Horror monsters need not be realistic to command attention, but they do need to tap into evolved attentional biases. A toothy, fast-moving shark is a closer fit with ancestral fears than is a lumbering, brown-eyed cow. As Saler and Ziegler observe, "since monsters, in one form or another, were an omnipresent feature of our evolutionary past, tales about slaying monsters ... have a salience and relevance for us that represent a heritage from our Paleolithic ancestors" (2005, p. 224)

Unnatural monsters achieve particular salience and enjoy superior mnemonic resilience because they violate innate intuitions (Grodal 2009). An angry ghost is more memorable and eye-catching than an angry person. Humans evolved a cognitive system that automatically and non-reflectively categorizes objects in the world and assigns to the objects certain domain-specific assumptions. When an object appears to violate those domain-specific assumptions—if a rock floats, a tree speaks, or a person passes through walls—we pay particular attention (Boyer 2001). Unnatural, category-violating horror monsters take advantage of this aspect of human cognition. They combine traits from, or violate expectations of,

distinct ontological categories. Other traits, typically traits that facilitate predation, may be amplified to make the monsters more fearsome, that is, to more effectively activate the evolved fear system.

The evil of most horror monsters is likewise explicable in evolutionary terms. Insofar as horror monsters are ascribed intelligible motives, they tend to be antisocial ones (Clasen 2014, Kjeldgaard-Christiansen 2016). Some horror monsters, such as most zombies, seem to be driven purely by predatory hunger and can hardly be characterized as evil, whereas others—the truly evil ones—are driven by a sadistic desire to inflict harm on others. Count Dracula is evil because he is clearly unconcerned about the suffering that he inflicts on his victims in his selfish pursuit of power (Clasen 2012a). He sustains himself on the dehumanization and degradation of others. Antisociality tends to be seen as evil because humans evolved to suppress behaviors that undermine sociality. This tendency evolved in response to the challenge of sustaining cooperative, cohesive groups. Stories play a vital role in transmitting and reinforcing prosocial norms (Gottschall 2012). Most literature—including horror literature—privileges prosociality over antisociality, which is particularly evident in agonistic structure, that is, the distribution of characters along a continuum ranging from negative (antagonists) to positive (protagonists). Antagonists tend to be represented as selfish, antisocial, power-hungry individuals, whereas protagonists tend to be represented as prosocial, helpful, unselfish individuals (Carroll et al 2012). Jonathan Harker’s attempt to save his fiancée and the world from the evil of Dracula in Bram Stoker’s 1897 novel is unselfish and good. Jack Torrance’s selfish and murderous pursuit of power and prestige in Stephen King’s *The Shining* (1977) is bad (Clasen 2017a). Consider also, as an atypical yet illustrative case, one of the most famous literary monsters of all time, Frankenstein’s creature from Mary Shelley’s *Frankenstein* (1831). The notoriously ambivalent monster is motivated not by selfish gain or sadistic pleasure, but by a prosocial desire to enter into cooperative alliances and to form procreative bonds. As he says, “I desired love and fellowship” (Shelley 1994, p. 165). His monstrosity lies not in his motives, but in his appearance—as he says, “the unnatural hideousness of my person was the chief object of horror with those who ... beheld me” (p. 94). This peculiar and dissonant combination of exterior and interior

qualities produces an aesthetically complex and interesting monster, one that illustrates the importance of motivation to the concept of monstrosity.

The structure of horror monsters, then, is explicable in terms of evolved cognitive tendencies. They are typically dangerous, antisocial creatures that mobilize our fear and condemnation, and they tend to be exaggerated or counterintuitive variations on ancestral threats to more effectively engage our interest and provoke strong emotional responses. This is a key claim in evolutionary horror study—an insight that could not have been reached without an understanding of human evolutionary history and the ancestral selection pressures that shaped the human mind.

The Pleasures and Functions of Horror

The primary function of horror literature, according to evolutionary theorists, is to provide an imaginative setting for vicarious experience with threat scenarios. Such experience is inherently rewarding because it serves the adaptive functions of emotional and cognitive calibration. There is a functional parallel to children's play activities, such as hide-and-seek and chase play, which afford vicarious experience with scenarios of hunting and predation and are likewise inherently rewarding (Steen and Owens 2001, Grodal 2009). When we enter imaginatively into fictional horror worlds and respond emotionally and cognitively to the events depicted and to the characters' responses to these events, we gain vicarious experience with negative emotion at high levels of intensity, and we develop coping strategies for handling such emotions. All of this may serve important adaptive functions. In Stephen Asma's words:

We use the imagination in order to establish and guide our own agency in chaotic and uncontrollable situations. The horror story is probably a permanent player in the moral imagination because human vulnerability is permanent. The monster is a beneficial foe, helping us to virtually represent the obstacles that real life will surely send our way. As long as there are

real enemies in the world, there will be useful dramatic versions of them in our heads. (2015, p. 954)

More than providing the pleasure of emotional stimulation and vicarious experience with danger, the best horror stories provide psychological and sociological insight and help calibrate our moral systems. Such stories give us access to the thoughts of fictional people as they respond to evil monsters or to the destruction of their worlds, and they give us access to (typically dark) nuances of social interaction. Take Stephen King's "The Mist" (1980) as an example. In this story, a strange mist descends on a small town. A group of people converge on a supermarket to seek refuge from the monsters hiding in the mist. Soon, however, deadly violence breaks out among the refugees who assemble into antagonistic groups and start fighting one another. This story is more about psychological and social responses to disaster than it is about supernatural monsters, and embedded in the story is a moral vision of how one ought to act in the face of such disaster. The best horror stories tend to be psychologically realistic, no matter how outlandish their monsters, which enables them to function as "instruments of subjective orientation—orientation in attitudes, emotional responses, values, and beliefs," in Joseph Carroll's words (2006, p. 43). Horror stories can tap into an evolved motive for imaginative absorption and thus help us make sense of the world and of the behavioral options available to us, particularly in scenarios of danger or existential crisis. As another example, consider Richard Matheson's story about a vampire apocalypse, *I Am Legend* (1954). Here, we follow the sole survivor of a vampire pandemic in his attempts to survive predation by the vampires, and more pertinently, in his attempts to make sense of a radically altered world and his own position in it. The narrative premise of the story is implausible, but the existential predicament depicted in it is not, and a responsive reader comes away from the novel with a rich and potentially instructive experience (Clasen 2017b). Horror thus helps us calibrate our values and sift through the limitless range of behavioral options uniquely available to big-brained humans.

Humans evolved to find pleasure in vicarious and aesthetically modulated experience, and horror literature provides such experience. Horror stories are about evil and the fragility of life, about human

interactions and social dynamics, and they can pose philosophical questions about the fabric and nature of reality in an engaging way. They frequently invoke monsters and morally charged supernatural forces—partly for the inherent (and evolutionarily explicable) fascination of such themes, but more pertinently as catalysts for essentially human dramas. That is how horror stories come to function as “instruments in subjective orientation,” in Carroll’s phrase; and as “one of the vital ways in which we try to make sense of our lives, and the often terrible world we see around us,” in Stephen King’s (Carroll 2006, p. 43, King 2010, p. 365).

Conclusion

Horror literature has been studied from a vast range of perspectives since the inception of academic horror study (Hogle and Smith 2009). Only recently have theorists begun applying evolutionary and cognitive psychology to the genre. An evolutionary perspective on horror converges with a commonsensical understanding that horror works by stimulating deep-seated emotions, but the evolutionary perspective lets us get into focus the causal mechanisms that underpin the functions and effects of horror. Only by understanding the evolved structure of the mind can we begin to understand how and why horror works, why horror literature tends to circle around few and evolutionarily relevant themes, and why certain monsters (such as giant sharks and murderous clowns) are consistently perceived as scary while others (such as cows) are not. The stories that captivate and frighten us fall within an extremely narrow subset of all logically possible stories—that subset, the possibility space of horror, is constrained by human nature. Hence, according to evolutionary theorists, an understanding of human nature, and the evolutionary process that gave rise to it, is indispensable to a comprehensive, scientifically consistent understanding of horror literature (Clasen 2017b).

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